



DECISION GUIDE

Should I Redesign My Website?

A practical way to look at the website you already have, understand what is working, spot what may need attention, and see what a redesign could actually involve.

The goal is not to sell you a new website.

It is to help you understand your current site well enough to decide whether the right next step is to keep it, improve it, or rebuild it.



Should I Redesign My Website?

Maybe you are looking at your website right now and wondering if it is time for a change. Maybe it has been a few years. Maybe the business has changed. Maybe customers are asking for things the site was never built to handle. Or maybe you just have a feeling that the site is not doing as much for the business as it could.

But here is the thing: a website that looks old is not automatically a website that needs to be rebuilt. And a website that looks modern is not automatically a website that works well.

So what is actually going on with your site? What is working? What is not? What could be improved without starting over? And what would a redesign really change if you did decide to do one?

That is what this guide is for. It is not here to convince you that you need a new website. It is here to help you look at the one you have with a little more clarity, so you can decide what makes sense for your business.

Keep what works. Improve what gets in the way. Rebuild when the foundation truly needs to change.

1. Take an Honest Look at the Site You Have

Start with the website that exists—not the website you remember, and not the website you wish you had. Open it on a desktop. Open it on your phone. Click through it like a customer who has never seen it before.

Look at the practical stuff first. Can somebody understand the business? Can they find the information they came for? Can they contact you? Can they complete the things the site is supposed to help them complete?

- ☐ A first-time visitor can understand what the business does.
- ☐ The most important services, products, or information are easy to find.
- ☐ Navigation labels make sense without inside knowledge of the company.
- ☐ The site feels comfortable to use on a phone.
- ☐ The important actions—call, email, book, buy, request a quote, sign up—are easy to complete.
- ☐ The content reflects the business as it operates today.
- ☐ Forms, links, buttons, and integrations work.
- ☐ Analytics and conversion tracking provide information you can actually use.
- ☐ Important pages can be found and indexed by search engines.
- ☐ Someone on the team can make routine updates without creating a technical headache.

If most of those boxes are checked, that is meaningful. It may mean the site needs attention, but not necessarily a rebuild.

And ask one more question: **What problem are we trying to solve?** A redesign should have a reason behind it.

2. “My Website Is Not Working” Can Mean a Lot of Things

People use that sentence to describe all kinds of problems. It helps to slow down and figure out which problem you actually have.

What you notice	What may be behind it	What to investigate first
It looks dated	Brand, typography, photography, spacing, or page hierarchy may no longer fit the business.	Ask whether the appearance is hurting trust or clarity. A visual refresh may be enough.
People leave without acting	Traffic quality, message mismatch, slow pages, weak calls to action, or missing information.	Look at landing pages and customer journeys before blaming the design.
Leads are down	Traffic, offer, conversion path, forms, trust, pricing, or follow-up could be involved.	Measure where the funnel is losing people.
Mobile is frustrating	Menus, layouts, forms, tap targets, or sticky elements may not translate well to smaller screens.	Test the real tasks on a phone and fix specific friction.
It is slow	Images, scripts, third-party tools, hosting, caching, or application architecture.	Optimize first. Rebuild only if the underlying stack is the limitation.
Updates are a pain	CMS setup, theme, plugins, permissions, or custom code may have become fragile.	Simplify the maintenance process; it may not require a new site.

A conclusion should come after the investigation, not before it.

3. The Keep → Improve → Rebuild Test

These are not three mandatory steps. They are three possible outcomes.

KEEP

Keep the site when the foundation is doing its job and the issues are relatively small. Maybe the content needs occasional updates. Maybe one form needs work. Maybe the photography is dated. Those are problems, but they are not necessarily reasons to start over.

IMPROVE

Improve the site when the foundation is usable but parts of the experience are getting in the way. You might rewrite pages, simplify the navigation, improve the mobile layout, optimize images, clean up tracking, improve accessibility, or rebuild a few problem templates. The rest of the site can stay.

REBUILD

Rebuild when the foundation itself has become the problem. That could mean the platform cannot support required features, the codebase is too fragile to maintain, the content structure no longer fits the business, or the current setup has accumulated so many workarounds that every change creates another problem.

One of the most useful questions you can ask is: **What would the new foundation let us do that the current one cannot?**

4. Look at the Website From the Customer's Side

You know where everything is because you work here. Your customers do not have that advantage.

Try a few simple tasks without helping yourself: find a service, find pricing, find the phone number, locate the service area, request information, make a booking, or find a product. Time how long it takes. Notice where you hesitate.

- ☐ The site tells me who the business is for.
- ☐ The main offer is clear without reading every word on the page.
- ☐ I can find what I came looking for.
- ☐ I know what to do next.
- ☐ I can tell why I should trust this business.
- ☐ I can complete the important task on a phone.
- ☐ I know what will happen after I submit a form or contact the business.

If possible, watch somebody who does not know the business use the site. Do not rescue them immediately. Their questions are often more revealing than another round of internal review.

The moments where they stop and ask “Where do I go?” or “What does this mean?” are exactly the moments worth writing down.

5. Content Can Be the Problem—Even When the Design Is Fine

A website can have beautiful photography, clean code, and a polished layout and still be difficult to use because the words are not doing enough work.

Look at the important pages and ask whether they answer the questions a real customer has. Is the service clearly explained? Is it obvious who it is for? Is the next step clear? Are important details buried in paragraphs? Does the site sound like the business today?

Before rebuilding, try a content-first improvement pass. Rewrite the homepage. Simplify a service page. Move an important piece of information higher up. Change a vague button to a specific one. These are small changes, but they can expose whether the larger problem is really the design.

- ☐ Important pages use clear, specific headings.
- ☐ Services and products are explained in plain language.
- ☐ Calls to action tell people what will happen next.
- ☐ The site answers common questions before customers have to ask.
- ☐ Outdated announcements, offers, embeds, and dead links are gone.
- ☐ Images support the message rather than simply filling space.
- ☐ Contact and location information are easy to find.
- ☐ Content is written for the customer, not for the people who built the website.

6. Check the Things You Cannot Judge by Looking at the Homepage

Some of the most important parts of a website are nearly invisible. They need to be tested.

Performance

Current Core Web Vitals focus on loading performance (LCP), responsiveness (INP), and visual stability (CLS). Current guidance uses 2.5 seconds or less for LCP, 200 milliseconds or less for INP, and 0.1 or less for CLS at the 75th percentile. These are useful benchmarks for real-world experience, but they are not the only measure of whether a page is good.

Search

Google's current Search Essentials emphasize that pages need to be accessible to Google, serve a working response, and contain indexable content. Google also recommends people-first content and crawlable links. A site meeting those basics is eligible for search, but that does not guarantee it will be indexed or rank well.

Accessibility

WCAG 2.2 is the current W3C Recommendation. Its four broad principles are perceivable, operable, understandable, and robust. In plain English: people need to be able to perceive the information, operate the interface, understand what is happening, and use the site with a range of technologies.

Try keyboard-only navigation. Check form labels and error messages. Look at contrast. Make sure buttons and links have meaningful names. Automated testing is useful, but it should be followed by human testing.

Technical checks matter because a redesign that looks better but introduces slower pages, broken tracking, inaccessible controls, or search problems is not a successful redesign.

7. Sometimes the Real Problem Is the Platform

There are times when the design is not the limiting factor. The system underneath it is.

Maybe the business now needs ecommerce, online booking, a customer portal, structured content, multiple locations, more complicated forms, a CRM connection, or a different publishing workflow. Maybe the current platform can handle all of that. Maybe it cannot. Find out before deciding that the site has to be rebuilt.

Question	What to look at
Can the team manage it?	Can normal content updates be made without a developer every time? Are permissions clear?
Can it support the business?	Look at ecommerce, booking, membership, portals, forms, structured content, and future requirements.
Can it integrate?	Review CRM, analytics, email, payments, scheduling, support, advertising, and other required systems.
Can it be maintained?	Look for outdated dependencies, plugin conflicts, tangled code, weak documentation, and fragile deployment.
Is it more complicated than necessary?	A simple site with a large stack of tools and workarounds may need simplification, not more features.

A platform should fit the work. The goal is not to own the most powerful stack; it is to have a system that can do what the business actually needs without creating unnecessary work.

8. If You Do Redesign, What Would Actually Change?

“Redesign” can mean a small visual refresh or a completely new website. Those are very different projects.

Approach	What changes	What may stay
Visual refresh	Typography, colors, imagery, spacing, components, and visual polish.	Most content, URLs, platform, and structure.
Experience redesign	Navigation, page hierarchy, calls to action, forms, and important user journeys.	Much of the technical foundation and useful content.
Template rebuild	Core page templates and reusable components are rebuilt for consistency and easier maintenance.	Content can often move forward with limited changes.
Content architecture redesign	Pages, navigation, URLs, content types, and internal linking are reorganized.	Useful content, media, and business information.
Full rebuild	Design, front end, platform/CMS, integrations, data structure, templates, and deployment are replaced or substantially reworked.	Only the pieces worth carrying forward.

A good redesign should be explainable. For every major change, there should be a reason. Better navigation. Easier editing. Faster pages. Clearer conversion paths. Better accessibility. A platform that can finally support the business.

9. Before You Commit to a Rebuild

Give yourself one last reality check. Look at the evidence you already have.

- ☐ I know the main jobs the website needs to perform.
- ☐ I know which parts of the current site are working.
- ☐ I have identified specific problems instead of relying on a general feeling.
- ☐ I have tested the important customer journeys on desktop and mobile.
- ☐ I have checked performance, accessibility, analytics, forms, and search visibility.
- ☐ I know which problems can be fixed without rebuilding.
- ☐ I know which requirements the current platform cannot support reasonably, if any.
- ☐ I understand what content, URLs, tracking, and integrations would need to move.
- ☐ I know how I will tell whether the project was successful.

Then write three lists: **Keep.** What is already working? **Improve.** What can be made better without replacing the foundation? **Rebuild.** What genuinely cannot be fixed without changing the foundation?

You may end up with a short Improve list and no Rebuild list. That is a perfectly reasonable result. You may find one platform limitation that changes the picture completely. The evidence should decide that—not the age of the website.

10. You May Not Need a New Website

And that is okay.

Maybe your website is basically sound. Maybe the navigation needs work, the service pages need better writing, the images are too heavy, the mobile form is awkward, and your analytics needs cleaning up. That is still real work, but it is very different from starting over.

Or maybe you do need a rebuild. If the platform cannot support the business, the structure has become too difficult to maintain, or the current architecture is making every improvement harder than it should be, a new foundation may save time and frustration later.

Either way, the useful question is not “Do I want a new website?” It is “What does the business need the website to do, and what is getting in the way right now?”

Take a look at the site you have today. Keep the things that are doing their job. Fix the things that are not. And before you decide to rebuild, make sure you can explain what the rebuild is solving.

That is really all this guide is trying to help you do: understand the website you have, understand the options in front of you, and make a decision based on what the business actually needs.

Keep what works. Improve what gets in the way. Rebuild when the foundation truly needs to change.

The right answer is the one you can defend with evidence—not the one that happens to produce the newest-looking website.

Technical references: Google Search Central — Search Essentials, technical requirements, JavaScript SEO, and How Search Works; web.dev — Core Web Vitals; W3C — Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.2 and accessibility principles.